In Defense of Insull

To the New York Herald Tribune:

Having been accustomed for so long a period to harmonize with your views I am grieved that, for the first time, I must emphatically disagree with you and rise in protest against your recent unkind references to Samuel Insull, builder of empires and benefactor of humanity. At this time, when he is being delivered into the merciless hands of his defamers, common fairness and justice demand that the deliberately misguided public be correctly informed in regard to his character and work.

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For more than fifty years Samuel Insull has led an exemplary, sober, industrious and honorable life. Loyal to his friends and supporters and generous to a fault, he fulfilled scrupulously his duties, met promptly his obligations and carried out to the letter all his promises. Throughout the land he had a reputation for fair and honest dealing, his word was as good as gold that used to be. The greatest financial institutions, the leading bankers, manufacturers and industrialists, with whom he transacted business, will bear such testimony without exception.

Contrary to the general opinion created, the greater part of his enterprises were among the most solid in the United States. They withstood all panics and hard times, paid uninterruptedly liberal dividends to the shareholders and are paying them now. Only a few could not weather the depression.

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The greatest injustice done to Insull is that no adequate idea has ever been given to the public of the scope and importance of his work. Samuel Insull, who came to this country as a boy, with nothing but genius and grim determination to succeed, has done more for the United States and the rest of the world than the New Deal is likely to accomplish. If we were to appraise his work in dollars, not merely by the undertakings developed under his guidance but by its universal effect, we would have to estimate it in hundreds of billions.

Some losses have been sustained in the recent collapse, but they are no more than a drop in the barrel of Heidelberg as compared with the values he has created. If the losers, instead of foolishly clamoring for vengeance, would unite in a helpful effort, he would work out the problem and return the money invested with a profit besides.

NIKOLA TESLA.

New York, May 4, 1934.